

March: GNOME Released

GNOME, a Desktop Environment for Linux, was released. Development on an alternative to the KDE Desktop Environment was precipitated due to the fact that KDE included proprietary code, and could not be licensed under the GPL. Started in 1997 by Miguel de Icaza and Federico Mena, it did away with the proprietary Qt widget toolkit that was the underpinning of KDE, and used the GTK toolkit, which was free.

March: Pentium III

The Pentium III was released. It had 9.5 million transistors, and improved upon the Pentium II by increasing the number of instructions to handle graphics load. The inclusion of a unique serial number in the processor that could be accessible over the Internet proved a controversial issue.

May: Napster Popularises P2P

And then 18-year-old Shawn Fanning created a program that allowed users to search for and share content on the Net. The program, called Napster, popularised the Peer to Peer (P2P) mode of file sharing. P2P was not pioneered by Napster; users had been using IRC (Internet Relay Chat) channels to do the same much earlier. But Napster, thanks to the client's user-friendly interface, is credited with making P2P hugely popular.

June: AMD Beats Intel With Athlon

AMD released its Athlon processor. This seventh-generation processor, after the K6 series, was aided by a collaboration between AMD and Motorola. For the first time, the AMD product was undisputedly superior than the Intel offering. It had 22 million transistors.

Ridiculous Domain Prices

Mark Ostrovsky sold the domain business.com for \$7.5 million; in 2007, the domain was resold for \$360 million. The InterNIC, the domain registering body of the Internet, allowed domains to be registered on a first-come-first-served basis. This allowed people to register domain names that were similar to the names of pop-